Meanwhile, where were the humans? There is now general consensus that, anatomically, modern humans evolved in Africa around 200,000 years ago. This fits both genetic data as well as archaeological remains. Genetic studies show that the San tribe of the Kalahari (also called the ‘Bushmen’) are probably the oldest surviving population of humans. Members of this tribe show the greatest genetic variation of any racial group and are therefore likely to be direct descendants of the earliest modern human population. [10]

Modern humans, of course, were not the first hominids to have walked the earth. More than a million years ago, pre-modern humans like Homo erectus used stone tools and had wandered as far as China and Java. At the time that modern humans were evolving in Africa, their close cousins, the Neanderthals, were already well established in Europe and West Asia. In other words, we are the last survivors of a large family tree and, in the early stages, it would not have been obvious that we would emerge as the most successful species. Indeed, there is evidence that our first attempt to leave Africa was a failure. Archaeological remains in the Skhul and Qafzeh caves in Israel show that modern humans may have made their way to the Levant about 120,000 years ago. Their passage may have been helped by the fact that the planet was enjoying a relatively wet and warm inter-glacial period that allowed them to wander up north. However, this climatic period did not last and a new Ice Age started. The early settlers either died out or were forced to retreat. Neanderthals, better adapted to the cold, probably reoccupied the area.

For the next 50,000 years, our ancestors remained in Africa. Around 65–70,000 years ago, a very small number, perhaps a single band, crossed over from Africa into the southern Arabian peninsula. [11] It is amazing that despite all their superficial differences, all non-Africans are descendants of this tiny group of wanderers. [12] This means that non-Africans have very little genetic variation. This has important implications for our susceptibility to global pandemics.